SPARK Team Launch

Monday, January 12, 2026

OUR FOCUS THEIR FUTURE

Scottsdale Unified SCHOOL DISTRICT

Your Hosts

Lea Mitchell

Assistant Superintendent, Education Services

Sarah Torrilhon

Director of Gifted and Advanced Academics

Michelle Irvin

Coordinator of the Arts and Physical Education

Superintendent Welcome

Community Building: *Me in 3+1*

Step 1:

Divide your age by 3

Example: 45/3= 15

Step 2:

Think of the big moments in your life that happened within each third so far.

Example of Eras:
0-15, 16-30, 31-45

Step 3:

Using the note cards, write a short summary of each era on the first 3 cards.

Example of Eras:

- Growing up…
- Degrees, Wedding, Baby
- Career focus, empty nesting….

Step 4:

On the 4th card, describe why you are excited to be a member of the SPARK team.

I'm excited to be a member of SPARK because…

Stand up, hand up, pair up and share

- Stand up, put your hand up and ***find a partner, introduce yourself and share your first "era",*** thank your partner and…
- Put your hand up, ***find a new partner and share your second "era"***, thank your partner and…
- Put your hand up, find another new partner and ***share your third "era"***, thank your partner and return to your seat.

SUSD Strategic Plan 25-26

Establishing Metrics:

Wildly Important Goals

Key Performance Indicators

Wildly Important Goals 2025-2030	**Excellence in Math:** 75% of 8th graders successfully completing Algebra 1
	Full and Thriving Schools: Increase capture rate and maximize capacity
Strategic Priorities	***Academic Excellence***
	Climate, Culture and Community Engagement
	Talented and Qualified Professionals
	Optimized Resources
	Future Focused

OUR FOCUS THEIR FUTURE

DISTRICT VISION

Engaging all students in world-class, future-focused learning

DISTRICT MISSION

We inspire, motivate, and empower all to think critically, act collaboratively, and embrace diversity for a life of intellectual exploration, community engagement, and personal growth.

OUR FOCUS THEIR FUTURE

DISTRICT VALUES

Excellence: *We nurture a growth-minded culture of high expectations, creativity, persistence, and self-discipline.*

Integrity: *We demonstrate honesty, transparency, and reliability through our words and actions.*

Empathy: *We welcome all with kindness, love, compassion, and joy.*

Trust: *We earn the confidence of stakeholders through accountability, openness, and authenticity.*

Inclusion: *We create an equitable environment where everyone is respected, treated with dignity, and has a sense of belonging.*

Unity: *We connect across communities to advance educational opportunities for all.*

OUR WHY:

because kids!

OUR COMMITMENT:

Elevate
Excellence
EVERY DAY.

OUR FOCUS:

THEIR FUTURE

Agenda for our time together

- Purpose, role and shared beliefs for SPARK
- Current Structures, Common Elements and Current Program Audit
- Visioning for the Future
- Reorganize to Strategize

Role and Purpose of SPARK

The Scottsdale Unified SPARK Team's role is to serve as the district's collaborative body for program development, review, monitoring, and continuous improvement of specialty and signature programs and specialty schools.

- The team's purpose is to:
  - (1) Develop and/or evaluate specialty school and signature program proposals,
  - (2) Recommend new program locations,
  - (3) Review program performance and status,
  - (4) Research unique and new school programming models,
  - (5) Provide implementation and strategic planning supports to schools/programs,
  - (6) Recommend the continuation or sunsetting of program status.

Synthesizing our collective beliefs…

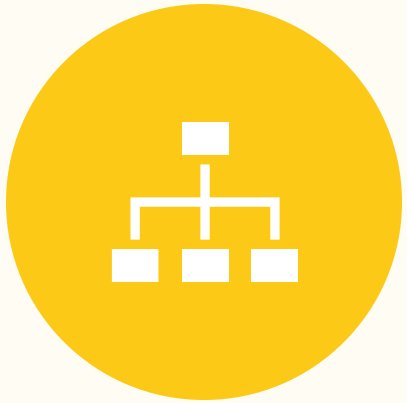
What do you believe should be the primary focus of this team for the next 18 months?

Shared Beliefs Carousel

- Find the BELIEF poster that matches the number you were assigned
- With your NEW group, take some time reviewing and discussing the poster.
  - Does the information reflect what your group thinks is important
  - Are there words or concepts you want to add or strikethrough?
- Select a member to stay and share
- Remaining members rotate from poster to poster
  - Listen to the group summary
  - Thumbs up if you agree or feel free to add a suggestion
- Back to your OG poster….as a group, finalize your belief statement based on the additional ideas shared

Breaktime

What’s Happening Now?



CURRENT STRUCTURES

COMMON ELEMENTS

CURRENT PROGRAM AUDIT

Current Structures

Dedicated Specialty School- a school site that implements a signature theme or themes across all grades and does not have a defined attendance boundary. All students who wish to attend the school must apply for and be accepted in the school through the SUSD centralized enrollment processes. All students enrolled in a Dedicated Signature School must participate in the program(s) theme.

Examples in SUSD: Cheyenne Traditional, Pueblo DLI

Current Structures

Schoolwide Specialty Program- a school site, with a defined attendance boundary, where the signature theme is implemented school-wide. All students attending the school participate in the thematic learning components of the program. Students who live outside of the attendance boundary who wish to attend the school must apply for, and be accepted into, the school through the centralized enrollment process.

Examples in SUSD: Navajo STEAM, Laguna STEAM, Anasazi PYP, Mountainside MYP, AVID @ Tavan, Hohokam, Ingleside, Arcadia

Current Structures

Signature Program within a School- a school site, with a defined attendance boundary, where the theme is implemented within the school, but not all students participate. All students wishing to attend the program must apply for and be accepted into it through the signature program processes.

Examples in SUSD: Desert Mountain IB, Saguaro MSA, Mohave DLI, Mohave MSA, Desert Canyon DLI, AP Capstone, CGP, CTE Academies/Programs

Common Elements and Quality Indicators

- Alignment and Purpose
- Evidence and Effectiveness
- Equity and Accessibility
- Cost and Resources
- Training and Support
- Impact on Students and Staff
- Implementation Feasibility
- Data and Evaluation
- Community and Stakeholder Support
- Sustainability

Quality Indicators…what did we miss?

With your table team

- Take 5-7 minutes to review the Quality Indicators Check-List
- Discuss which elements you feel are MOST important
- Discuss any additional indicators that we missed

Let's Practice

In teams, work collaboratively to review current programming implementation for some of our current program models.

- ***International Baccalaureate***
- ***Scottsdale Math and Science Academy (MSA) at Saguaro and Mohave***
- ***Dual Language Immersion***
- ***Traditional***
- ***STEAM***
- ***Comprehensive Gifted Program (CGP)***
- ***AVID***

Which indicator areas came through strong during your initial review?

Which indicator areas need additional info or study?

Programming Info

International Baccalaureate	Math and Science Academy	Dual Language Immersion	Cheyenne Traditional
STEM Certified Schools	Comprehensive Gifted Program (CGP)	AVID	*What's Next?*

Vision for the Future

4 FUTURES

POST SECONDARY PATHS TO PURPOSE

Enrollment	High school graduates enroll in an accredited postsecondary institution (community college, university, or technical school) prepared to succeed in credit-bearing coursework without remediation. This includes readiness for a range of academic pursuits, from performing and visual arts to liberal arts to STEM, healthcare, education, etc., with a clear plan for completion and career alignment.
Employment	Graduates enter the workforce in high-demand, high-skill, high-wage fields equipped with industry-recognized certifications, technical skills, or stackable credentials that align with employer needs. This path emphasizes dual and concurrent enrollment, work-based learning, internships, apprenticeships, and/or arts and CTE programs completed in high school that translate to immediate and sustainable employment.
Enlistment and Service	Graduates commit to serving their community, their country, or the world by enlisting in the U.S. Armed Forces or engaging in a structured local, national, or international service experience such as AmeriCorps, Peace Corps, faith-based missions, or community service corps. This path includes students who are physically, mentally, and emotionally prepared for structured service and leadership development, often with future education or career benefits.
Entrepreneurship	Graduates launch or actively participate in entrepreneurial ventures, small businesses, or start-ups—leveraging creativity, business acumen, digital tools, and real-world problem solving. This path includes students who have completed entrepreneurial coursework, developed business plans, or engaged in incubator or pitch competitions, and who demonstrate the mindset to build and sustain value-driven enterprises.

Vision for the Future

8 ESSENTIALS

STUDENTS GRADUATE WITH SKILLS, COMPETENCIES, AND MINDSETS FOR THE FUTURE

KNOWLEDGE AND LITERACY	Foundational Knowledge and Literacies	Demonstrates essential academic and practical skills to understand, communicate, and confidently navigate the world. • Reads, writes, and speaks effectively across content areas • Applies mathematical and scientific reasoning to everyday and academic situations • Interprets and uses visual, numerical, and financial information • Recognizes the influence and importance of history, arts, and culture on shaping knowledge and understanding • Connects ideas across subjects and applies learning in new and meaningful ways
	Digital Fluency	Uses digital tools and technologies ethically, responsibly, effectively, and creatively to learn, communicate, and solve problems—while adapting as technology continues to evolve. • Navigates digital environments to access information and connect to others • Critically evaluates and discerns media messages, sources, and digital influence • Uses digital tools and platforms to create and communicate • Understands and adapts to essential and emerging technologies, including AI • Recognizes the impact of technology on individuals, communities, and society
DYNAMIC THINKING	Critical Thinking and Problem Solving	Applies logic, reasoning, and thoughtful analysis to make decisions and solve problems in academic and real-world settings. • Analyzes information and breaks down complex problems • Connects information and ideas to build new understanding • Applies learning in new and unfamiliar situations • Considers evidence, logic, and ethics to make well-reasoned decisions
	Creative and Innovative Thinking	Uses imagination, curiosity, and originality to ask meaningful questions, generate ideas, explore possibilities, and create new or improved solutions. • Explores ideas with curiosity and an open mind • Generates original ideas and builds on the ideas of others • Designs solutions that are creative, purposeful, and grounded in real-world needs • Takes risks, learns from failure, and adapts to improve outcomes

Vision for the Future

8 ESSENTIALS

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PERSONAL DEVELOPMENT	Self-Awareness and Management	Uses personal insight and reflection to guide decision-making that supports well-being and success in school, work, and life. • Recognizes and reflects on personal and cultural identity to understand oneself • Identifies individual strengths, challenges, motivations, values, and goals • Balances priorities by managing time and energy to support both achievement and wellness • Understands and regulates emotions to sustain focus and encourage positive outcomes • Makes decisions that consider both personal success and the impact on others
	Adaptability and Lifelong Learning	Demonstrates resilience, adapts to new circumstances, and continually develops the knowledge, skills, and mindset needed to thrive in a changing world. • Embraces new ideas, perspectives, and approaches • Adjusts plans and strategies based on feedback, experience, or new information • Persists through challenges and overcomes setbacks with determination and an open mind • Pursues opportunities to develop new skills and deepen understanding
CONNECTION AND CONTRIBUTION	Communication and Collaboration	Demonstrates high emotional intelligence by applying interpersonal skills to build understanding, strengthen relationships, and accomplish shared goals. • Expresses ideas clearly using verbal and non-verbal communication • Actively listens and engages in respectful dialogue • Values diverse backgrounds, perspectives, and lived experiences of others • Demonstrates reliability and accountability in collaborative work • Navigates and manages conflict constructively
	Ethics and Impact	Demonstrates empathy, integrity, and responsibility to build safer communities, contribute to a healthy democracy, and promote societal well-being. • Participates in civic life through service, leadership, and community involvement • Builds knowledge of social and governmental structures in local, national, and global contexts • Honors history and traditions as foundations of community and society • Considers the effect of their decisions on others and on the greater good • Acts with honesty, fairness, and accountability

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Making Connections

With your tablemates, spend a few minutes chatting about how the NEW State 48 Profile of a Graduate aligns with our SUSD Mission and Vision.

Vision for the Future

Current ideas, concepts or programs to be explored by SPARK this spring

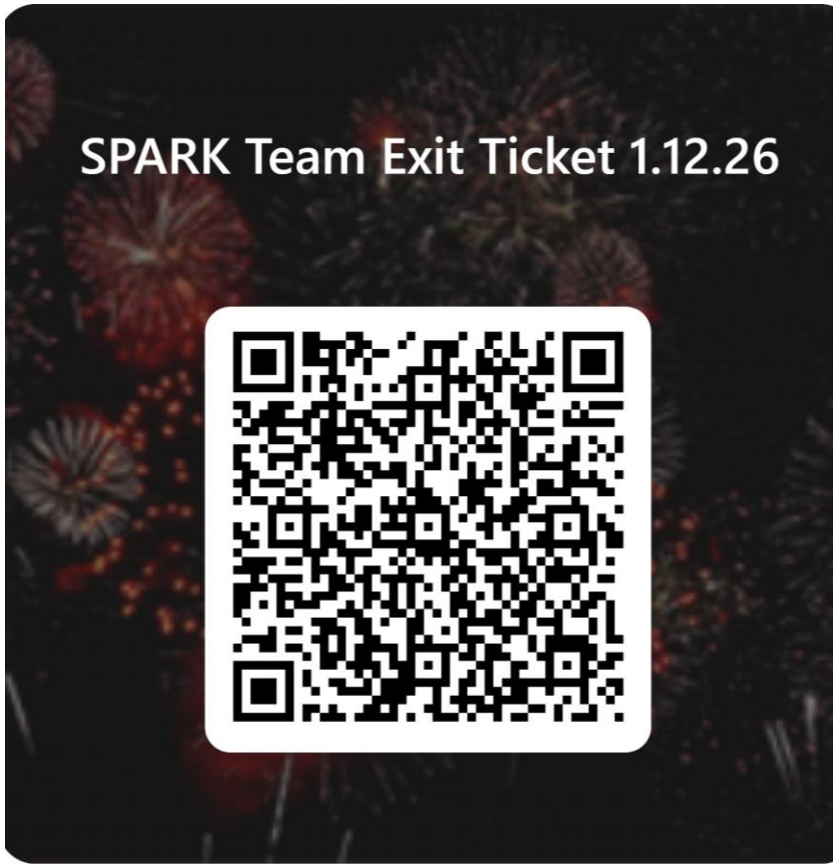
- Fine and Performing Arts Specialty School
- Gifted and Advanced Academics Specialty School

Additional concepts, ideas, programming to explore in the future

✓Take 5 minutes as a team to brainstorm additional concepts you would like SPARK to consider

Next Steps

- Complete exit ticket to indicate study group interest
- Meet at study teams (2-3 times) between now and spring break
  - Use the quality indicators to guide your study efforts
  - Research similar program offerings across the state and country
  - Develop a short presentation / materials set to share your findings, questions, ideas
- At next SPARK meeting we will…
  - Hear presentations from each group
  - Offer questions, feedback and suggestions in a consultancy protocol
  - Review SPARK Notebook (record of our efforts) and determine what else should be included



THE SPARK TEAM

INNOVATE • ENGAGE • EXCEL

SUSD SIGNATURE PROGRAMS